

SONY HDR-XR100E Stunning performer

The HDR-XR100E is Sony's gift to the masses — an HD camcorder that's priced on a par with some of the costlier non-HD camcorders around. It's a handsome looking device — black, with a mixture of gloss and matte finishes. It's not very large, but owing to the 80-GB hard drive, it comes across as being much bulkier than the flash-based camcorders. Owing to the colour and the shape, it looks a bit like the Canon HF11.

The back of the LCD viewfinder has a lot of colourful stickers, a cheery respite from the all-black body. This viewfinder is crisp and clear with great colours, crisper than the viewfinder on its sibling, the Sony HDR-CX100. The viewfinder is also fast and there is never any sort of lag which admittedly is rare to find these days, but super annoying when found. Going with the norm that HD camcorders do not have great zoom, this one has only 10x. Although this may be enough for most uses those looking at shooting outdoors at distant scenery should look elsewhere.

At full zoom, the performance of the Optical Image Stabiliser (OIS hereon) is impressive, and we were able to focus on the number plates of vehicles moving some 300 m away clearly enough to read them. At full quality settings (equating to super fine quality at a resolution of 1080i), the HDR-XR100E will chew up 16 MBps, which is a lot of space, despite this, the massive 80-GB hard drive gives more than 500 min of recorder video. Therefore, it's safe to say your batteries will run out before the drive is full.

The layout of the buttons on this camcorder is excellent and the menu system very well thought out. In fact, the



Sony HDR-XR100E

entire menu system is touch-screen based and the settings are very simple even for total newbies to find their way around. The record button is ergonomically placed and even people with large hands will never have to bend their thumbs much. This deserves special mention as continuously bending the thumb while shooting can become painful after just 10 to 15 minutes. Image quality of the videos is really good and we felt as though we were watching an HD movie, which in reality we were. All videos have great resolution and very good detail.

The resolution is sharp and it's worthwhile to invest in a large-screen LCD / plasma display for someone really into capturing and watching a lot of such videos — smaller displays do not do justice to the video output of this camcorder! The camcorder focuses fast at the long end of the zoom and indoor shooting is also good, which means low light performance is good and the output videos never seemed dim. Still image quality is also pretty good. In fact, at a size of 9 x 10 inches, it's as good as most mid-range digital cameras. The OIS system also works well for zooming in for photos. We did not register any image shake during the entire test, save for when we tried some over adventurous panning just to check how far the OIS system could cope.

At a price of Rs. 36,999, this camcorder is quite frankly a steal. Sure, it won't replace your camera. But, if you intend to do a lot of quality video shooting, the Sony HDR-XR100E is just the thing. With its massive resolution and superb all-round quality you'd be daft not to at least check it out.

CANON HG20 Silver Streak

The HG20's bulk makes the Sony CX100 look really tiny and cute. That doesn't mean it's not attractive. It sports a refreshingly different light grey / light silver and

chrome colour scheme that keeps things interesting. The fit and finish is good with the lettering CMOS Sensor written in chrome. The lens is large and gives the camcorder an executive feel. The still shot / video select dial is conveniently located on the back of the camcorder in such a way that it comes really close to your thumb, which is ideal, and people with larger hands will not have any problems. There's a small rough textured, raised portion on this dial that coincides with your thumb and makes switching from play and record mode a snap.

However, people with large hands may need to bend their thumbs a bit. There are AV, Component and HDMI outputs provided. A connection for an add-on microphone is also included. The LCD viewfinder is pretty decent and quite bright. The record button is very conveniently located and you don't have to put in extra effort to navigate your way through. Even large handed people will find it comfortable. On a negative note, the photo click button is really hard to press and causes shake when you don't have support while shooting. Halfway down the click, the autofocus is activated and after that the button becomes really stiff. Canon also provides a neat remote control unit with this camcorder and we tested this; the unit works flawlessly. The HG20 ships with a 60-GB HDD, more than enough for even frequent users.

Thankfully, unlike the Sony camcorders that power on when the LCD flap is opened, there is a chrome-finished and hard to miss power button on the top of the body. The camcorder can be switched on and off regardless of the viewfinder being open or closed. Image quality on the HG20 is really good and its OIS system works really well to deliver shake-free videos most of the time. The only time we had an issue with shake was when we wilfully jiggled our hands when shooting to check the effectiveness of the OIS system. The HG20 does very well indoors as well, and thanks to its 12x optical zoom outdoor shooting is equally good. Still shot quality is also good, with great highlights and detail.

We were a little taken aback when we learned this camcorder was priced at Rs. 95,995, which is quite honestly a sizeable chunk of cash and more than this camcorder



Canon HG20

How we tested

We divided the camcorders we received into two categories: regular and HD camcorders. After this we segregated them into categories based on the media they use. We logged all the specifications of each camcorder and also recorded the bundled software. A high weight was given to ergonomics. This is overlooked by many people, but is very important since it affects usability to a great extent. Finally, for performance, we tested each camcorder's video capabilities both indoors and outdoors under both natural and artificial lighting. We also tested the quality with the zoom and used variable zoom throughout the testing. Finally, we checked the efficacy of the image stabilisation at the long end of the zoom. This is very important because when zoomed in, even minor hand movements can cause blur and spoil the video. We tested the quality of still shots as well as the quality of audio captured while shooting the video. All the images were transferred to a test PC with a GeForce 8800 GTX graphics card and viewed on a ViewSonic VX2025WWM monitor that has an 8-bit, MVA panel and is very suited for image and video editing work.